



External USB TV-Tuners

Pinnacle PCTV MediaCenter 100e

Specs: External USB 2.0, Full-Featured Remote Control, Coaxial In, Composite In, S-Video In, Pinnacle MediaCenter Software

Our Verdict: The Pinnacle PCTV MediaCenter 100e with its cool blue LED and curved shape is the most elegant-looking of all the USB TV-Tuners we've seen. Bundled with it was one of the best PVR software we've seen, as well as the Pinnacle MediaCenter software, which gives your Windows XP PC functionalities similar to a Windows XP MediaCenter PC. The feature-rich remote allows you to exercise full con-

trol over every function of the TV-Tuner.

TV picture quality was also very good, and when we tested it, it detected 73 of 97 of cable TV channels, which is decent. The capture quality was the best in its class, and it didn't drop a single frame during our capture test.

This TV-Tuner is priced much higher than the others in its category, but it's a winner by virtue of sheer image quality and great performance.



Runner-Up: **Tech-Com SSD-TV-811**

External Set-Top TV-Tuners

Tech-Com SSD-TV-712

Specs: VGA In, VGA Out, S-Video In/Out, Audio In/Out, Coaxial In, VGA-to-TV Box Cable, Stereo Cable

Our Verdict: The Tech-Com SSD-TV-712 is the only no-frills TV-Tuner in this category, concentrating instead on pure functionality.

The image quality is excellent. It detected all available TV channels in our test.

This TV-Tuner gets the Zero1 Award

because of its rock-bottom price as compared to the other products in its category.



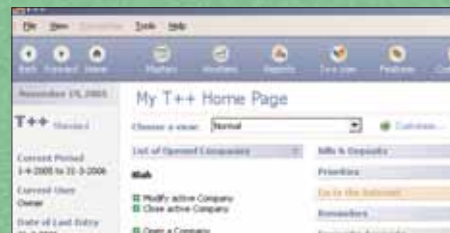
Runner-Up: **AVerMedia AVerTV Box 9**

SOFTWARE Accounting Software

T++

Our Verdict: The interface of the T++ package is a cross between that of a Web browser and Windows Explorer. It has a professional layout, with the menu laid out on one screen, so you don't need to hunt around for the various options.

The software's home page provides all accounting data at a glance, and this can be configured. Data entry forms are also very user-friendly. Navigation through different forms is a snap. T++ has a feature set



almost identical to Tally's, with a few extras thrown in. All in all, this is an easy-to-use software rich on features, available at an affordable price.

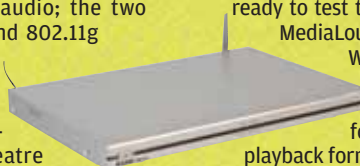
Runner-Up: **Tally 6.3**

D-Link MediaLounge DSM-320

The slender MediaLounge has many connecting ports at the back. Most of these are for outputs such as optical and coaxial SPDIF, S-Video, composite video and RCA stereo audio; the two input ports are for Ethernet and 802.11g (Wi-Fi) to interface with the PC. OK, there's no need to worry about so many connections: they are provided so as to support a full-fledged home theatre system's requirements, and you won't need them all. Of course, if you *do* have a full fledged home theatre system, the manual should make it clear what goes where. Connecting to a TV is very simple—just install the necessary software on the PC and configure the

network to access the DSM-320 either wirelessly or via Ethernet.

Once the installation process is done you are ready to test the streaming capability. The MediaLounge can play back the MP3, WMA, AIFF and also playlist (M3U and PLS) formats; it supports five photo image formats and popular video playback formats (MPEG 1/2/4, Quicktime, AVI and XviD). There is only one button on the front panel, the On button; the remote is what you'll be using all the time. You can browse through your PC with the TV as the display, and run any supported media on your home theatre system. Now, forget about watching movies on your PC!



Showstoppers!